

Permanence begins at home. And family wealth fails because families fail. What we want to do is to create as much permanence as possible in those things that are within our control—first, in the family itself and then in its money.

So let's return to the old-fashioned approach, the so-called "nuclear family" or "contemporary family" model. In this approach, you get married and you do what comes naturally until something else that comes naturally comes naturally, if you know what we mean.

Most people do what most people do—they build a family randomly. They go off to school. They meet someone. They end up living somewhere. Then family life starts. They end up in a career. The children go to the local school. They might attend the local church. Then they become entrenched in the local mass culture. They get caught up in social pressure to do the same things that everyone else is doing.

The same is true of the conventional rich. They go Republican. They stay in the mold. They buy the right house, the right car. They attend certain social events. They give to the right charities. They compete with the other rich people to look successful. As their wealth grows, so does their consumption. Later, they become more wealth consumers than wealth producers.

Serious Old Money families do things differently. They create their own culture. They're relatively independent. They plan their lives purposely. And their time horizon is much longer than those of normal families. They think in terms of 20, 50, 100 years, or longer. . . .

They leverage the natural cycles of life using the talents of family members, young and old, to build the family business and the family wealth. Youth and energy may be valuable at producing wealth. But old age and wisdom are essential to holding onto it.

The young people are sources of energy, enthusiasm, and new ideas. The older members of the family are sources of experience.

These older members of the family can play the role of elders. They can:

- Mediate disputes (finding the best, most consensus-building resolution).
- Enforce the decision-making rules, but not set those rules.
- Tell the stories and history of the family.